Lesson 27 material: Infants: Discussion, Listening and Reading

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 3: Verb Tenses and Narration · The Human Lifespan

8.1: Discussion

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Answer the following questions based on your experience and opinion. Read five classmates' posts and respond to two classmates pointing out any similarities or differences, asking clarifying questions, or giving your opinion on a point they make.

1. What can help children's brain develop? How can parents help children's brains develop?
2. Can technology be beneficial for children? How? Why not?

8.2: Listening-How Every Child Can Thrive by Five

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3.1.2.1. Exercise 1-Listening Comprehension

Watch the video How Every Child Can Thrive by Five and build a basic understanding to prepare you for this chapter's reading. Answer the questions to check your comprehension.

1. By roughly 7 years old, the child's brain is _____ of an adult brain.

a. 30%
b. 50%
c. 75%
d. 90%

2. Which of the following is NOT one of the five ways adults can help children thrive?

a. Connecting
b. Talking
c. Playing
d. Technology
e. A healthy environment
f. Community

3. What does serve and return mean?

a. Connect, talk, and play
b. Throwing a ball and returning a ball
c. Building vocabulary
d. Playing peek-a-boo

4. According to the video, how do children feel when they lack connection?

a. Lonely
b. Confusion and stress
c. Lost
d. Trauma

"How Every Child Can Thrive by Five" by Molly Wright is licensed by TED under CC BY-NC-ND 4.0

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- How Every Child Can Thrive by Five: https://www.ted.com/talks/molly_wright_how_every_child_can_thrive_by_five

8.3: Reading-Mirror Stage

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

3.1.3.1. Exercise 2-Reading Comprehension

Read the passage below and answer the questions that follow.

1"Mirror stage" refers to the point in time when infants and toddlers start recognizing their reflections in the mirror. Research has shown that, although babies are fascinated with images of themselves and others in mirrors from a very early stage, they do not begin to recognize that the images in the mirror are reflections of their own bodies until the age of about 15 to 18 months. In psychology, there has been a debate about the mirror stage's importance in identity formation.

2In 1936, psychologist Jacques Lacan proposed that the mirror stage was part of an infant's development from 6 to 18 months. By the early 1950s, Lacan's concept of the mirror stage had changed slightly; he no longer considered the mirror stage as a moment in the life of the infant, but as representing a permanent structure of identity. Lacan felt that understanding and processing one's reflection was a key part in the development of identity.

3In 1953, Lacan wrote, "The mirror stage is a phenomenon to which I assign [two values]. In the first place, it has historical value as it marks a decisive turning point in the mental development of the child." In the second place, he claimed, it represents an essential connection between the person and his or her concept of identity.

(Picture: Image 20 "Japanese Child-Various Situations" by Ajari is licensed under CC BY 2.0.)

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4Lacan's concept of the mirror stage was strongly inspired by earlier work by psychologist Henri Wallon. Wallon noted that by the age of about six months, human infants and chimpanzees both seem to recognize their reflection in a mirror. While chimpanzees rapidly lose interest in the discovery, human infants typically become very interested and devote much time and effort to exploring the connections between their bodies and their images.

5Many other psychologists disagreed with the notion that recognizing and processing one's reflection in the mirror was a key component in identity development. In 1988, Raymond Tallis wrote a paper claiming that the theory was inaccurate because it would mean that people who were blind from birth would lack selfhood and be unable to contribute to society. In 1996, Dylan Evans claimed that while Lacan's theory that mirrors were key to forming identity was important, it had become so abstract by the 1950s that it was untestable.

1. PART A: Which of the following statements best summarizes a central idea of the text?

a. The human brain is wired to recognize faces everywhere, even in inanimate objects.
b. Recognizing one's own face, as well as the faces of others, is crucial to forming a healthy identity.
c. Mirror stage describes the period in which infants begin recognizing their reflection, though its significance in identity development has been debated.
d. Mirror stage is the phenomenon in which two or more close individuals subconsciously mimic each other's expressions, actions, and/or gestures.

2. PART B: Which of the following quotes best supports the answer to Part A?

a. "…children are fascinated with images of themselves and others in mirrors…." (Paragraph 1)
b. "The 'mirror stage' refers to the point in time when infants and toddlers start recognizing their reflections in the mirror…. In psychology, there has been a debate about the mirror stage's importance in identity formation." (Paragraph 1)
c. "Lacan felt that understanding and processing one's reflection was a key part in the development of identity." (Paragraph 2)
d. "…human infants typically become very interested and devote much time and effort to exploring the connections between their bodies and their images." (Paragraph 4)

3. Which of the following best describes the evolution of Jacques Lacan's concept of the mirror stage?

a. Lacan changes the ages of the infantile mirror stage from 15-18 months to 6-18 months, allowing for a larger age range when babies can recognize their reflections.
b. Lacan calls the mirror stage as a phenomenon but later labels it as a general part of normal human (and chimpanzee) development.

c. Lacan's theory becomes more abstract, the concept taking on a more philosophical tone than a scientific one.
d. Lacan alters his concept so that it is not considered just a small period of an infant's life, but an essential and lasting element of a person's identity.

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16.6: Chapter 6

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4.6.1. Listening Comprehension

00:14 [Baby cooing]

00:32 What if I was to tell you

00:34 that a game of peekaboo could change the world?

00:41 Sounds impossible, right?

00:43 Well, I'm here today to prove it's not.

00:48 Hi, I'm Molly and I'm seven.

00:50 And this is my little friend, Ari.

00:52 Say "Hi," Ari.

00:55 Hi.

00:57 Oh, and this is my neighbor, Amarjot.

01:00 He has to take Ari away now to get ready for our experiment.

01:05 But don't worry, they'll be back.

01:08 My talk today is about some powerful things you grownups can do.

01:12 that shape us as children and the adults we become.

01:16 How do I know?

01:18 Because my parents and people around me did them early and often.

01:23 I know not all kids are as lucky.

01:25 Some of my friends, some kids at my school and many around the world.

01:30 And I would really like to help change that.

01:34 Thanks to scientists,

01:35 we now know just how important the first five years are

01:39 for our health and development,

01:41 especially our brains.

01:43 Ari started learning long before he was even born,

01:46 from inside his mommy's tummy.

01:48 When Ari was born,

01:50 he was tiny and he cried all the time.

01:55 He was always hungry and he pooped a lot.

01:59 [Laughter]

02:01 Now he laughs and giggles and makes funny noises.

02:05 But those are just the changes we hear and see.

02:08 That's way more going on inside.

02:12 So, let's talk more about our brains.

02:16 The blue bag is a rough size and weight of a healthy baby's brain at birth.

02:22 The red one is a baby's brain after the first year.

02:26 It almost doubles in volume.

02:30 And by my age, it's almost 90 percent the volume of an adult brain.

02:38 Our brains develop faster in our early years

02:41 than at any other time in our lives.

02:45 It can create up to one million neural connections every second.

02:51 But we need your help.

02:53 Our healthy development depends on these top five things,

02:58 One, connecting; two, talking;

03:02 three, playing; four, a healthy home,

03:05 five; community.

03:07 All of this helps our brains and us reach our full potential.

03:12 So what's something you can do that can really make a difference?

03:17 Scientists call it serve and return.

03:20 That's just a grown-up way of saying connect, talk and play with us.

03:26 And here's the really big news.

03:29 Amarjot, Ari, you ready?

03:31 (Audio) Amajat: Ready?

03:33 Molly Wright: Copycat games build imagination and empathy.

03:37 (Amarjot and Ari laughing)

03:41 Naming games build vocabulary and attention.

03:45 Amarjot: Daddy. Ari. Daddy. Ari.

03:50 MW: And games like peekabo -- yep, peekaboo --

03:53 actually build memory and trust.

03:56 Amarjot: Peekaboo!

03:58 MW: Each time you talk to us, play with us, make us laugh,

04:03 it not only builds and strengthens our relationships and mental health,

04:08 it actually teaches us some of the most important life skills,

04:12 from making friends to taking the test,

04:15 to getting a job,

04:16 to one day maybe even starting a family of our own.

04:21 Interactions early and often matter.

04:24 Take it from me,

04:25 the seven-year-old up here talking about brain science.

04:29 (Laughter)

04:30 OK, now let's see what happens when the connection is taken away.

04:37 So now he's trying to get his dad's attention again.

04:40 He's reaching out like, "That was fun, why have you stopped?"

04:46 (Ari cries)

04:48 I know it's important for adults to use their devices sometimes,

04:53 but kids are hardwired to seek out meaningful connections,

04:58 not receiving them causes confusion and stress.

05:02 OK, Amarjot, please re-engage.

05:06 Amarjot: Ah, there's Ari.

05:08 (Ari laughs)

05:13 MW: Now what if our whole childhood was like that last 30 seconds?

05:19 How hard it would be for a child to feel calm.

05:23 To feel safe.

05:26 To learn to trust anyone.

05:28 And the lifelong impact that would have.

05:32 That makes me feel sad.

05:38 Ari only reacted the way he did and recovered so quickly

05:43 because the connection between him and his dad is usually so strong.

05:48 The positive relationships with the grown-ups in our lives

05:51 gives kids the confidence we need

05:54 to try new things, to explore and be a kid.

06:01 So please,

06:04 try to remember the most special period for our development is

06:09 the first five years.

06:12 Starting from inside mommy's tummy.

06:15 What's something really impactful you can do?

06:18 Serve and return.

06:21 And when?

06:23 Early and often.

06:26 Please give it up for a Amarjot and Ari.

06:29 (Applause)

06:37 Every moment together is an opportunity

06:41 to connect, talk and play.

06:45 Imagine the difference we could make if everyone everywhere did this.

06:53 To us, the children,

06:56 it's so much more than just a game.

07:04 It's our future.

07:06 Thank you.

07:07 (Applause)

07:08 See? Peekaboo really can change the world.

07:11 (Applause)

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